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# California lawmaker introduces bill to ban artificial dyes in school cafeterias — with some kids' favorites making list

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A California state lawmaker introduced new legislation Tuesday that seeks to ban artificial dyes in food items sold in school cafeterias — and kid favorites like Lucky Charms, Gatorade, Skittles and more are on the chopping block.

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel proposed the bill to prohibit California public schools from offering foods that contain synthetic food dyes and additives because the chemicals are believed to be linked to health effects including behavior issues, cancer and hyperactivity.

"California has a responsibility to protect our students from chemicals that harm children and can interfere with their ability to learn," Gabriel said in a statement. "As a lawmaker, a parent, and someone who struggled with ADHD, I find it unacceptable that we allow schools to serve foods with additives that are linked to cancer, hyperactivity, and neurobehavioral harms."

The legislation seeks to ban foods containing Red 40, Yellow 5, Yellow 6, Blue 1, Blue 2, and Green 3 as well as titanium dioxide in California public schools. Goran – stock.adobe.com

He said the goal of the legislation is to encourage companies to produce their products with natural alternatives to artificial additives.

It doesn't ban any specific foods or products itself.

The Democrat's bill specifically targets six dyes — Red 40, Yellow 5, Yellow 6, Blue 1, Blue 2, and Green 3 — as well as titanium dioxide, a brightening agent that is outlawed in all foods across the European Union over concerns it could damage DNA.

The artificial dyes are often found in sugary cereals, candies, soft drinks and other junk food. billtster – stock.adobe.com Opponents of the additives say studies show a potential link between their consumption and behavioral issues in children. JHVEPhoto – stock.adobe.com

The Food and Drug Administration says that color additives when used according to its regulations are safe for consumption and that no causal link has been established between the chemicals and behavioral effects in children.

"The totality of scientific evidence indicates that most children have no adverse effects when consuming foods containing color additives, but some evidence suggests that certain children may be sensitive to them," the FDA states.

But supporters of the bill, including watchdog groups, the Environmental Working Group and Consumer Reports, have called the chemicals harmful to children.

The FDA says that no casual link has been established between the chemicals and behavioral effects in kids. Adriana – stock.adobe.com

And a 2021 report by the California Environmental Protection Agency concluded that "consumption of synthetic food dyes can result in hyperactivity and other neurobehavioral problems in some children."

It also noted a dramatic increase in ADHD diagnoses among American children and teens in recent years.

If the bill is signed into law, California would be the first state in the country to ban artificial additives from schools.

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